objective of Act East is to preserve a favourable balance of power in the Indo–Pacific. [15]

The transition from ‘Look East’ to ‘Act East’ required a change in India’s strategic vocabulary, one that captured the wider geopolitical dynamics of play. Indian strategists began to discuss and debate the idea of the Indo–Pacific between 2007 and 2013. [16] The term already had currency in the biological sciences, referring to an ecologic zone of warm water spanning parts of both the Indian and Pacific Oceans. It also had historical antecedents in the ancient, medieval, and colonial periods, when the Indian and Pacific Oceans were linked through trade and cultural routes. But as a contemporary strategic concept, it gained ground after Japanese Prime Minister Shinzo Abe referred to the need to imagine a broader Asia as part of the ‘confluence of the two seas’—the Indian and Pacific Oceans—in a speech to the Indian Parliament. [17]

After China began to assume a greater maritime presence in the Indian Ocean after 2008, Indian commentators such as C. Raja Mohan argued that ‘the seas of the western Pacific and the Indian Ocean must be seen as a single integrated geopolitical theatre, the “Indo–Pacific”’. [18] The official adoption of the term in India and other countries followed suit, including in Australia’s defence and foreign policy white papers and in various official articulations by Japan. Indian Prime Minister Manmohan Singh referenced the Indo–Pacific in a May 2013 speech in Tokyo. Subsequently, in a January 2017 address to the Raisina Dialogue, Prime Minister Narendra Modi said that India ‘believe[s] that respecting freedom of navigation and adhering to international norms is essential for peace and economic growth in . . . the Indo–Pacific’. [19] Somewhat belatedly, in late 2017, the United States began to adopt the term and described the Indo–Pacific as a priority region in its 2017 National Security Strategy (NSS). [20] Modi elaborated upon the theme in a 2018 keynote address at the Shangri-la Dialogue in Singapore, where he emphasized that the Indo–Pacific was consistent with ASEAN centrality, allaying concerns in Southeast Asia about its use. [21] Thus, the Indo–Pacific gradually became part of the official strategic vocabulary of India, the United States, Japan, and several other countries.